

Shore bombardment
USS *Idaho*'s big 14-in guns bombard Okinawa shortly before the first amphibious assault on April 1, 1945.

THE BATTLE OF OKINAWA

The assault on Okinawa was the largest amphibious operation of the Pacific war. More than half a million Allied personnel were involved in the battle for control of an island regarded by the Japanese as part of their homeland. In many ways the operation resembled the struggle for Iwo Jima, only on a larger scale. The preliminary naval bombardment to soften up the defenses, begun on March 21, was so intensive that Okinawans called it the "Typhoon of Steel." As at Iwo Jima, the initial landings on April 1 were unopposed. The Japanese soldiers on Okinawa, numbering over 100,000, were hidden in well-prepared defensive positions from which they could only be removed by months of hard infantry fighting.

OPERATION TEN-GO

The Allied naval forces at Okinawa consisted of the American Fifth Fleet —which included an astonishing 40 carriers and 18 battleships—and Vice Admiral Sir Bernard Rawlings's Royal Navy Task Force, under American operational control. The fleet was in an exposed position, within range of Japanese air bases on Kyushu island in southern Japan. It was also close enough to tempt the remnants of the Japanese navy into a final sortie, Operation Ten-go. On April 6, Admiral Seiichi Ito sailed out of the Inland Sea on board *Yamato*, the largest battleship in the world, accompanied by the cruiser *Yahagi* and a handful of destroyers—at that point the entire naval force that Japan could muster. His mission was to attack the Allied fleet off Okinawa. None of the ships was expected to return; they had only been supplied with fuel for a one-way trip.

On April 7 the 11 carriers of Vice Admiral Marc Mitscher's Task Force 58 launched three waves of aircraft. Swarming around the *Yamato*, they struck it time and again with bombs and torpedoes until the battleship turned turtle and exploded, sending up a plume of smoke that could be seen 125 miles (200 km) away. The cruiser and four destroyers were also sunk and the operation abandoned.

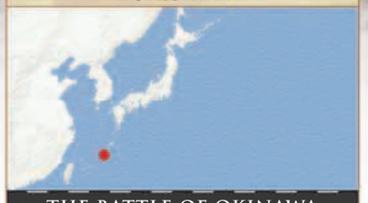
FINAL SACRIFICE

The Allied fleet did not find it so easy to cope with air attack. On April 6, Japanese aircraft under launched the first mass kamikaze attack with over 300 aircraft. By crashing their aircraft onto warships, young half-trained pilots caused fearsome damage, even though few of them penetrated the combat air patrols and massed fire of the Allied fleet. In raids that continued through to the third week of June, the kamikazes sank more than 40 Allied ships, damaged some 200 others, and killed over 5,000 sailors. The fall of Okinawa came as a relief to battered and exhausted naval personnel.



Kamikaze attack
A Japanese suicide pilot about to crash his plane into the starboard side of the battleship *Missouri* during the battle for Okinawa.

WORLD WAR II



THE BATTLE OF OKINAWA

Date	March 21–June 23 1945
Location	Okinawa, Ryukyu Islands, Japan
Result	Allied victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES **BRITISH COMMONWEALTH**	**JAPAN**

COMMANDERS

Raymond Spruance	**Seiichi Ito**

FORCES

Ships: c.1,300	**Ships:** unknown

LOSSES

Men: 4,028 **Ships:** 79	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** 16

> "WE WATCHED EACH PLUNGING KAMIKAZE WITH THE DETACHED HORROR OF ONE WITNESSING A TERRIBLE SPECTACLE RATHER THAN AS THE INTENDED VICTIM."
>
> **VICE ADMIRAL C. R. BROWN**, DESCRIBING JAPANESE KAMIKAZE ATTACKS